TEACHING SCRIPT | LESSON 12

1 Corinthians Part 4

A 50 Minute Teaching Script

BIG IDEA Christ's bodily resurrection guarantees the resurrection of his people and makes steadfast service worthwhile.

BEFORE CLASS Write on the board: If death really has been defeated, what should look different in the way Christians live now? Under it write: How does Christ's bodily resurrection guarantee the resurrection of his people and make steadfast service worthwhile?

0:00-5:00 Opening question prayer and connection

Good morning. In Lesson 11, Paul asked whether Christian freedom and spiritual gifts were being used to build up Christ's body in love. Today Paul reaches the doctrine that gives Christian work its future: the resurrection of the dead.

Our opening question is: If death really has been defeated, what should look different in the way Christians live now? Allow several answers. Do not correct every answer yet. Then point to the controlling question: How does Christ's bodily resurrection guarantee the resurrection of his people and make steadfast service worthwhile?

Paul's answer is not simply that souls go to heaven when people die. His claim is stronger and more concrete: Christ was bodily raised, those who belong to him will be bodily raised and transformed, death itself will be destroyed, and therefore life in Christ is never wasted.

Let's pray. Risen Lord Jesus, ground our faith in what you have done, strengthen our hope in what you will do, and make us steadfast in the work you give us today. Amen.

5:00-13:00 The gospel received and witnessed

Ask the reader to read 15:1-8. Paul begins by reminding the Corinthians of the gospel they received, on which they stand, and through which they are being saved.

The words received and passed on describe careful transmission of an established message. Paul is not inventing a theological explanation years after the fact. He is handing on the earliest Christian proclamation: Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, was buried, was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures, and appeared to witnesses.

Burial confirms that Jesus truly died. Resurrection means God acted bodily, not merely that Jesus' influence lived on. 'According to the Scriptures' places both death and resurrection within God's saving plan.

Paul then names witnesses: Peter, the Twelve, more than five hundred believers at once, James, all the apostles, and finally Paul. Use this list in two ways. It is apostolic testimony: those commissioned by Christ proclaim what they encountered. It is also historical evidence: Paul names people and says many were still alive when he wrote.

The witnesses do not make faith a laboratory experiment, but they do show that Christianity is anchored in a public claim about what God did in history. Paul's own transformation from persecutor to apostle displays the grace he proclaims.

13:00-20:00 If Christ has not been raised

Ask the reader to read 15:12-19. Some Corinthians apparently wanted a risen Christ without a future resurrection for believers. Paul says those claims cannot be separated. If the dead are not raised, Christ was not raised.

Trace the consequences. Preaching is empty. Faith is futile. The apostles misrepresent God. Believers remain in their sins. Christians who have died have perished. If hope in Christ reaches only this life, Christians who suffer for the gospel are to be pitied.

Paul's logic tells us that resurrection is not an optional doctrine added to the real gospel. Remove it and the entire Christian claim collapses. The cross is not God's saving victory if Jesus remains conquered by death.

Ask: Which consequence most clearly shows you why resurrection is essential? Take one or two answers, then move quickly to Paul's reversal in verse 20.

20:00-28:00 Firstfruits and the defeat of death

Read 15:20-28. Begin with Paul's great reversal: But Christ has indeed been raised from the dead. Firstfruits were the beginning of a harvest and the pledge that the rest would follow. Christ's resurrection is not an isolated exception. It guarantees the resurrection of those who belong to him.

Paul contrasts Adam and Christ. In Adam, humanity shares mortality and death. Those who belong to Christ share the life of the risen Christ and will be raised at his coming. Paul is not teaching that everyone is saved regardless of faith; verse 23 identifies the promised company as those who belong to Christ.

Keep Paul's sequence broad. Christ has already been raised. At his coming, his people are raised. Every hostile rule, authority, and power is abolished. The last enemy, death, is destroyed. Christ presents the completed kingdom to the Father so that God may be all in all.

This passage gives a destination, not a detailed end-times chart. It does not settle the millennium or every interval between events. Do not let the class build a chart bigger than Paul's point: Christ will reign until every enemy is defeated, including death.

If someone asks why the Son is subjected to the Father, explain that verse 28 concerns the completion of Christ's saving mission, not inferiority in divine nature. The Son willingly presents the completed kingdom to the Father. The triune God reigns without rival; Christ does not stop being divine or stop reigning.

If someone asks about baptism for the dead in verse 29, acknowledge that the phrase is genuinely uncertain. Paul may refer to vicarious baptism practiced by some Corinthians without endorsing it, or to baptism as hope for mortal bodies destined to die. Many proposals exist. What is clear is Paul's argument: a baptismal practice connected with the dead makes no sense if there is no resurrection. Do not build a doctrine of proxy salvation from an obscure practice Paul never commands.

28:00-39:00 What kind of body will be raised

Ask the reader to read 15:35-44 and then verses 47-49. Paul answers two questions: How are the dead raised, and with what kind of body? His seed illustration holds continuity and transformation together.

A seed must be sown, and the plant that grows is connected to that seed, yet wonderfully different in form. God already gives bodies suited to different kinds of life. The God who created such variety is able to give his people bodies suited for resurrection life.

Follow Paul's contrasts. The body is sown perishable and raised imperishable; sown in dishonor and raised in glory; sown in weakness and raised in power; sown a natural body and raised a spiritual body.

Spiritual body does not mean ghost. Paul keeps saying body. Natural and spiritual describe the source and quality of life. The present body belongs to mortal life inherited from Adam. The resurrection body is fully embodied life, transformed and empowered by God's Spirit.

In the same way, when Paul says flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom, he means mortal and corruptible humanity cannot enter God's final kingdom unchanged. That phrase does not contradict bodily resurrection; it explains why transformation is necessary.

We should resist speculation about age, appearance, or the mechanics of resurrection. Paul's promise gives us what we need: real continuity, glorious transformation, freedom from decay and weakness, and conformity to the risen Christ.

39:00-45:00 Mystery victory and steadfast work

Ask the reader to read 15:50-58. Paul now answers what happens to believers who are alive when Christ returns. Not all believers will die, but all must be changed.

At the final trumpet, the dead are raised imperishable and living believers are transformed instantly. The mortal is clothed with immortality. Then death is swallowed up in victory.

Death's sting is sin, but God gives the victory through Jesus Christ. Paul does not end with a timetable or an invitation to speculate. He ends with therefore.

Because resurrection is certain, stand firm. Refuse to be moved from the gospel. Give yourselves fully to the work of the Lord. That work may be hidden, difficult, or unfinished when we die, but it is not in vain because death does not have the last word.

Ask: Where are Christians most tempted to believe that faithful work is pointless or wasted? Allow a few concrete answers.

45:00-50:00 Chapter 16 final charge homework and prayer

Briefly summarize chapter 16. Resurrection hope does not make the Corinthians less concerned about ordinary life. They are to give regularly for believers in need, support faithful workers, honor dependable servants, and maintain loving relationships across churches.

Read 16:13-14. These commands summarize the letter: be alert, stand firm in the faith, be courageous, be strong, and do everything in love. Courage without love becomes pride and domination. Love without firmness becomes sentimentality. The gospel calls the church to both steadfast truth and self-giving love.

Here is the lesson in one sentence: Christ was raised, his people will be raised, death will be defeated, and therefore nothing faithfully done in the Lord is wasted.

Before next week, read 2 Corinthians 1-7. Mark where Paul connects suffering, weakness, comfort, integrity, reconciliation, and the power of God.

Let's pray. Father, thank you for raising Jesus Christ and promising resurrection life to all who belong to him. Make us alert, firm, courageous, strong, and loving. Keep us faithful in work that is never in vain. Amen.